Whispers of the Stars

A board game combining A War of Whispers (game)
with Perhaps the Stars (novel).
2-4 players
2 hours
v1.1

OVERVIEW

On the board, five mighty armies are at war for the world. But every player can give commands to every army via covert agents. Only you know which of the five are your favorites.

You win if your favorites conquer more land than the favorites of your opponents.

CREDITS

This game is a **reskin** of *A War of Whispers* (2019) by Jeremy Stoltzfus & Starling Games. It is mechanically identical, with a different narrative theme. The story comes from the novel *Perhaps the Stars* by Ada Palmer. More credits at the end of this rulebook.

NARRATIVE CONTEXT

It is the year 2454 CE. Earth is divided between a handful of well-intentioned, but deeply opinionated governments. They claim to be constructive 'Hives', not oppressive empires. Yet this distinction strains as they whirlpool towards war.

It is the shrewd & subtle powers that will steer this contest of political Leviathans.

SETUP

To start the game, each player takes a **player board**, agent cubes, and set of 5 loyalty cards. Place the circular “Round 1” round marker beside the “Start” space on the board.

Providence has selected 1 player to go first. Discover which. That player takes the **first player** marker.

Give each player 5 **loyalty cards**, 1 of each color. Loyalty cards are the ones with a large symbol at the top, the name of the Hive, & no other text. They will shuffle these 5 & deal them face-down onto the 5 loyalty slots of their player board. You may peek at your own cards at any time during the game.

Shuffle each of the 5 Hive **decks** & place it next to that Hive's section of the board.

For each location on the map **with a number** printed under it, place that many troops (cubes) of the matching color on that location.

THE PLAYERS

- Romanova - The nominal world government, almost forgotten because it lacks an army.
- Utopia - The mystical terraformers of Mars with their fabulous technology.
- Gordian - The brain scientists with an incredible & actionable understanding of the human mind.
- Madame - The criminal conspiracy promising satisfaction of your taboo urges, such as exegesis.

THE BIG FIVE HIVES

There are 5 Hives on the board, each represented by a different color:

- the European Union - Dark Blue
- the Humanist Hive - Yellow
- the Cousins Collective - Pale Blue
- the Mitsubishi Corporation - Red
- & the Masonic Empire - Purple

MAP SYMBOLS

Harbinger: At the end of the game, only these locations matter. See LOYALTY CARDS & SCORING.

Fortified Position: Kill 1 attacking cube immediately, whenever attackers enter this location.

Settlement: The supply limit in this location is 6 troops, not 4.

2, 3, etc

How many troops (cubes) start the game in this location.

LOYALTY CARDS AND SCORING

Loyalty cards are your primary means of winning the game. You have a total of five loyalty cards, one for each Hive.

You have five corresponding loyalty slots on your player board: 4x, 3x, 2x, 0x, & -1x.

Your loyalty cards define how many points a Harbinger location is worth to you, if the Harbinger is controlled by that Hive at the end of Round 4.

Example: At the end of the game, your loyalty cards are flipped to reveal their Hive side. If your Cousin loyalty card is placed on the 3x loyalty slot and the Cousins Hive ends the game controlling 3 Harbinger locations, you will earn 9 points at the end of the game (3 x 3 = 9 points).

For example, the score for each of your loyalty cards could be:

Mitsubishi: 4 loyalty x 2 Harbinger locations = 8 points
Cousin: 3 loyalty x 3 Harbinger locations = 9 points
Europe: 2 loyalty x 1 Harbinger locations = 2 points
Humanist: 0 loyalty x 4 Harbinger locations = 0 points
Mason: -1 loyalty x 2 Harbinger locations = -2 points

Your total score would be 17 (8 + 9 + 2 + 0 - 2).

GAMEPLAY OVERVIEW

The game is played in 4 rounds; each round has four phases:

1. Deploy Agents Phase: Starting with the first player and proceeding clockwise, each player removes and deploys agents to VIPs, the 4 squares of each Hive on the perimeter of the board.
2. Hive Turns Phase: Each VIP takes an action.
3. Cleanup Phase: Add the round marker to the next space on the round tracker; then each player discards down to the hand limit of 5 cards.
4. Swap Phase: In player order, each player may swap 2 of their unrevealed loyalty cards. If you choose to do so, you must reveal both of the swapped loyalty cards. They remain revealed for the rest of the game.

The flow of these phases is indicated by the arrows around the perimeter of the board. They flow from the Deploy Agents space on the board, onward to each of the VIPs, to the round tracker, and finally to the Expose and Swap Loyalties spaces. You will move the round marker piece around the edge of the board, marking these spaces to track where you currently are in the round.

The game has 4 rounds. Pass the 1st player marker clockwise at the end of each round. After the fourth round, the game ends immediately and scoring commences.

DEPLOY AGENTS PHASE

Each Hive has 4 VIPs (themed around Logistics, Opposition Leader, Marshal, and Hive Leader) printed on the board upon which you can place agents. Narratively, this means your agent is persuading, manipulating, or somehow controlling various characters who work for that Hive.

Step 1 (Retrieve Agents): Except on the first round, starting with the first player and proceeding clockwise, remove 1 of your agents currently on the board (if any).

Step 2 (Deploy Agents): Starting with the first player, take turns placing 1 agent on any available Hive VIP on the board until each player has placed 2 agents. The effects of these Hive VIPs are detailed in the following section.

2-Player Games: In a 2-player game, each player places 3 agents instead of 2.

HIVE TURNS PHASE

The Hive Turns Phase begins with the European Hive and proceeds clockwise around the board. During a Hive's turn, each VIP in that Hive will take one available action determined by the player who controls it. VIPs act in clockwise order as these appear on the game board, starting with the 1st and following the arrows up to the 4th. Available actions are described in the VIPs section below.

The player who controls a VIP is determined as follows:

• If a VIP has a player's agent deployed on it, that player controls that VIP.

• If a VIP has no agents, the player who owns the next agent (to the right, clockwise) within this Hive will control that VIP. If there is no agents to its right, no player will control it and it will do nothing as its action.

Example: The Utopia player has placed an agent in the 4th square of the red Hive (Mitsubishi), and the Gordian player has placed an agent on the 1st square. On the red Hive's turn, the Gordian player will control the 1st square's action. Since both the 2nd & 3rd squares are empty and the Utopia player controls the nearest agent to the right (the 4th, *aka* Chief Director Dominic Seneschal), the Utopia player controls all three remaining squares & will be in charge of those actions.

Hive Control

A map location is controlled by a Hive if it has at least 1 troop there, or if it is one of their home locations and contains no enemy troops. A home location is a location whose color matches the Hive's color.

Example: When a purple location has no troops on it, the Mason Hive controls it. However, a purple location containing 1 European troop would be controlled by the European Hive.

Controlling Harbinger Locations

At the end of the game, the number of Harbinger locations (stars) a Hive controls is multiplied by a player's loyalty to that Hive, granting the player that many points towards their final score.

VIPs

Each VIP has one or more available actions to choose from, as indicated on the game board. These actions are described here.

Many actions are written as [Resource] x [Location Symbol]. The number of copies of the right-side thing the Hive controls determines how many of the resource on the left it receives. For example, one of the Cousin actions offers 1 card per 3 Fortified Positions they control. If they control at least 3, it produces 1 card. If they control at least 6 (wow!), it produces 2 cards.

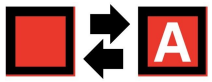
Alternately, the left-side symbol may show a gun, meaning this action produces troops.

If the symbol on the right is simply a number, then the action always produces that quantity of the resource each time it is used.

Cards produced go to the active player's hand. Troops produced will be in the color of the active Hive, & must be placed in locations that Hive controls.

If a Hive has no more troops to place, you may not select a troop-producing action. If there are only enough troops left in the game box to partially fulfill this action, you may take this action and simply place the ones that are available.

Swap Agent Action



Swap agents between this VIP & any other VIP within this Hive, then immediately take that new VIP's action.

(This does not move the round marker. The round marker will subsequently proceed to the Supply arrow to the right of the Swap square.)

Attack Action

Attack one enemy location adjacent to a location controlled by the active Hive. Move any number of troops from a single adjacent location controlled by the active Hive into the chosen location.

If any troops are being moved from a conquered location (e.g. a location containing the active Hive's troops which is not one of its like-colored home locations), you must leave at least 1 troop behind. You can never completely abandon a conquered location.

Combat

Combat occurs when troops from one Hive move into a location controlled by another Hive. Damage is applied to each side by killing (discarding) troops at a 1:1 ratio until one or both sides are depleted. If either side has any troops remaining, they have won the battle.

You cannot use the Attack action to simply shift troops among a Hive's controlled locations, it must be used to attack an enemy-controlled location.

Example: A player orders the Masons to attack with 3 troops, at a neighboring European location that has 2 troops. The 2 defending troops thus eliminate 2 of the attacking troops, but also eliminate themselves in the process. 4 troops are returned to the game box. The 1 surviving Mason troop ends the action occupying the formerly-European location.

Regions with Fortified Positions destroy 1 attacking troop whenever an attack enters this location.

Example: Europe attacks with 3 troops, and Mason defends with 2 troops and a Fortified Position. The Fortified Position destroys one of the attacking troops, leaving 2 attacking troops against 2 defending troops. All troops are killed and returned to the game box. The Masonic Hive retains control of the contested location as it is one of its home locations.

It is not illegal to give troops 'foolish attack orders' that are detrimental to the troops. You might attack with just 1 cube against a Fortified Position, for example.

Checking Supply

At the end of a Hive's turn, a location may only contain 4 troops. If there are more than 4 troops, return excess troops to the game box. If a location contains a Settlement, it has a higher limit of 6 troops. On the red Supply arrow, check supply only for red troops, & so on for the other Supply arrows.

MARK THE ROUND

Place the current round marker on the next available space on the round tracker. The first player marker now passes to the next player clockwise. If the last round marker is placed, the game ends (without

performing the Swap and Cleanup Phases), and you proceed to Final Scoring (see below).

SWAP STEP

Starting with the first player and proceeding clockwise, you each have the opportunity to swap any two of your facedown loyalty cards.

To swap two loyalty cards, simply switch the loyalty slot in which the two loyalty cards you chose are currently positioned in and flip them face up so the Hive symbols are now visible. These are now revealed and cannot be swapped in subsequent rounds.

Note that there are only 3 Swap steps, as you can see on the board. There is no Swap step between the last action of the last round & the end of the game.

CLEANUP STEP

At this point, each player must discard any cards in excess of the maximum hand size of 5. (Holding 6 or more cards at other times is fine, but all excess cards are discarded at this step.)

CARDS

Throughout the game, you will be acquiring cards and adding them to your hand. These can be played from your hand to affect the game in a variety of different ways.

Note: Card abilities often allow you to break a rule of the game. Therefore if there is a conflict between a general rule and a card ability, follow the instruction on the card.

Playing Cards

Normal cards are called action cards. At the top is a large Hive symbol. Below, there are 3 abilities, with costs of the pattern A, AA, & AB, respectively.

You can play an action card immediately before, during, or immediately after the action of any of your VIPs.
Exception: The default ability of Mitsubishi & Humanist action cards is to replace your current action, so these are played *instead* of your action, not before or after it.

You can play cards of any Hive regardless of the current VIP or which Hive you use the card to benefit. You can collect a Cousin card & later use it to benefit the Masons, for example.

To play an action card, choose 1 of the 3 abilities on that card. Each ability has a cost. The symbols next to the ability indicate cards that must be discarded to pay for that ability. The card you are playing counts as a “discard” for this payment. For this reason, the 1st ability on each card can be played without discarding additional cards. The 2nd ability is better & will require you to discard this card & another card of the same Hive. The 3rd ability is best & requires this card & another card of a specific other Hive.

Example: To play the Europe-Mitsubishi ability on a European Hive card, you’ll first need to discard 2 cards: this card, which is European (dark blue), and a Mitsubishi (red) Hive card. The icons next to this ability remind you about this. This is not in addition to any other cards; two cards total will leave your hand & be shuffled back into the decks. Then continue with your current action, which is now enhanced: the *Peacewash* ability converts rather than destroys the attack's victims.

Resolve one card’s effects before playing and resolving the next card.

Any time a card is played or discarded, it should be shuffled back into the Hive deck it belongs to.

FINAL SCORING

The game ends after the fourth round marker is placed at the end of the fourth round. Reveal all loyalty cards and score them as

described under 'Loyalty Cards & Scoring' above. The player who scores the most points is the winner. If two players are tied for highest score then the player that swapped loyalty the least wins. If any players are still tied, the player with the most cards in hand wins.

COMMON TERMS

- **Active Agent**: The agent that gives a player control of the active VIP.
- **Active VIP**: The VIP that is currently under the Round marker.
- **Troop**: A single military unit, represented by a colored cube.
- **Empty**: Containing no troops. It may still contain printed symbols (or agents, if using the advanced deployment rule below).
- **Friendly**: Describes troops belonging to the Hive that controls the location. For example, when instructed to add friendly troops to a formerly-purple location that is currently occupied by red, you add red troops.
- **Home Location**: Locations printed in purple on the map are the purple Hive's home locations, etc.
- **Kill**: Remove a troop from the board.

DETAILS & CLARIFICATIONS

Lying is legal in this game. Everyone is welcome to lie about their cards, their plans, or to make false promises.
(Lying about the rules to deceive a beginner would be unsporting, however.)

In general, you may never make a choice that leaves the game completely unchanged. If your action is a choice between drawing zero cards & placing 2 troops, you must choose to place 2 troops.

You can never choose zero as the number of troops in an attack.

However, if *all* your options at the current moment leave the game unchanged, then you of course have no choice. Simply proceed. This often happens with Darcy Sok (Cousin).

Also, remember that while zero-impact choices are not legal, self-destructive choices are. You can attack with 1 troop into a Fortified location, for example.

ACTION CARD CLARIFICATIONS

Humanist x1 effect: This must be done before taking an action, you are exchanging one possible action for another. If the second square is in a different Hive, take that action on behalf of the second Hive. Play then continues clockwise from the first (abandoned) square, advancing the round marker as normal. If there are no empty VIPs, this ability cannot be used.

Mitsubishi x1 effect: This must be done before taking an action, you are exchanging one possible action for another. If the second square is in a different Hive, take that action on behalf of the second Hive. Neither square needs to be occupied by an agent, as long as you control both squares. Play then continues clockwise from the first square whose action was forfeited, advancing the round marker as normal.

Mason x1 effect: You may move any number of troops from one qualifying location to another. However, you **may not abandon** a conquered location.

Europe x2 effect: All attacking and defending troops in the combat are killed. A single troop can be sacrificed as an attack to kill many defending troops this way, even if the defending space has a Fortified Position.

Europe-Mason (The Prince Speaks) effect: If there are no adjacent locations controlled by that Hive, return the troops to the game box.

Cousin-Mitsubishi (World-Ringing River) effect: The troops are moved from any one location the active Hive controls into the location being attacked, then combat resolves. This cannot be used to abandon a conquered location. Supply limits are calculated afterwards as normal.

OPTIONAL RULES

By default, none of these optional rules are in play. But the players may agree before the game to use some or all of them (in any combination).

OPTIONAL RULE: Assigning Agents to Regions
When assigning agents during the Deploy Agents Phase, instead of assigning an agent to a VIP you may choose to assign it to any location on the map (even if another player's agent is already there).

A player's agent in a location counts as a Harbinger knowledge symbol *for that player only*. Players can have a maximum of two agents deployed to the map. Regions may contain more than one agent, but not from the same player.

Agents played to a location can be retrieved at the start of the Deploy Agents phase, just like any other agent. Agents cannot be added or removed from the map in any other way.

Example: The Utopia player has deployed an agent to a purple map location. At the end of the game, whatever Hive controls this location scores this player points based on their loyalty to it. For instance, if the European Hive controls this location at game's end and the Utopia player has a 4x loyalty to the European Hive, then the Utopia player will score 4 points for this agent.

OPTIONAL RULE: Wild cards
A wild card has all 5 Hive symbols & no text. There are 10 included. Shuffle 2 into each deck during setup.

When playing an action card, you may discard a wild card as the 2nd card of an ability's cost. The wild card counts as whichever of the 5 Hives you wish.

OPTIONAL RULE: Event cards
There are 2 event cards for each Hive. Shuffle them into the appropriate decks during game setup.

An event card has a warning at the top to reveal it immediately when you draw it. Do so, then do whatever it says. You will have to perform some effect, but you will have some choice in the specifics. Then remove it from the game. (Unlike other cards, event cards are not shuffled back in.) Note - you do not get to keep drawing *in addition to* the event card. The event card *is* your draw.

Special cases:
As with all choices in this game, you may not execute an event card in a way that has zero impact on the board or cards.
However, it might be impossible for the event card to have any effect at this moment. In that case, discard it & DO draw again as compensation.

OPTIONAL RULE: Offer cards
There are 2 offer cards for each Hive. Shuffle them into the appropriate decks during game setup.

An offer card instructs you to play it during an opponent's action. (These are the same as the cards from the Dark Alliance expansion of AWoW.)

It is possible for the opponent to decline the offer. In this case, the card returns to your hand, with no effect except that everyone has seen the card.

Lying - It is perfectly legal to lie about your cards or plans in this game. Thus, it is legal to claim (honestly or falsely) that you have a specific offer card in hand, make promises involving it, & leave your opponent hanging when they fulfil their end of the promise & you decline to play the offer card.

FULL CREDITS

- *A War of Whispers* (2019) is a board game designed by Jeremy Stoltzfus & released by Starling Games.
- *Perhaps the Stars* (2021) is a novel by Ada Palmer.
- The Hive & Romanova flag images are by UnusualFrequency.
- This game, *Whispers of the Stars* (2024), is a retheme of *A War of Whispers* by Alex Pear.